

Five **5**-Minute Plays

Five little plays with things you already have. Each one grows with your child, from birth to five.



1. Peekaboo
Blanket



2. Pots-and-Spoons
Band



3. Cup Tower Crash



4. Window Walk



5. Sock Friend Says
Hello

5

PLAYS

0

THINGS TO BUY

0 min

PREP

0-5

YEARS, WITH A
GROWN-UP

Five minutes, any time

These five plays need nothing to buy and no setup. Each one has a ladder: find your child's age and start there. Five minutes is plenty; stop whenever your child is done.

Pause and wait

Say a little, then stop and count to five in your head. A look, a sound or a wiggle is an answer.

"Ready, set... (wait)"

Say what you see

Put words to what your child is doing, right as it happens. No quiz questions needed.

"A car! A big red car."

Sing and gesture

Add a tune, a clap or a big movement. Little ones join in with their hands before words.

"Loud! ... quiet."



Talk, sing and read in the language you know best. Every talk line works in any language. A sign, a point or a tap on a talking device counts as communicating, just like a word.

How to use this

Print it or keep it on your phone. Pick one play a day, or the same favorite five days running. **Most children love 2–3 of these** and ask for them again and again. That's the plan working.

Why five minutes?

Young children learn in back-and-forth moments with the people who love them: a look, a laugh, a turn, a word. Short, happy plays fit into real days. This is something to add, never a test.

Find your child's age on every play

▲ 0–1 yr

■ 1–2 yrs

★ 2–3 yrs

● 3–5 yrs

The color, the shape and the words all say the same thing, so you never need color alone.

PLAY

1

Peekaboo Blanket



With a grown-up



No prep



About 5 min



Nothing to buy



You need: A small blanket or towel

How to play

- 1 Hold the blanket up between you.
- 2 Say “Where did I go?” and wait.
- 3 Drop it and say “Peekaboo!” Do it again, and again.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT

“Where’s... (wait) there you are!”



Why it works

Things that go away and come back are thrilling for little ones. Every “peekaboo!” is a turn you take together.

- 2 **Tired? 1-minute version:** Hide your face behind your hands three times.



Safety: Blanket play is for awake time with you. Take the blanket away before any baby sleeps. Hide only in open spots, never in cupboards, boxes or appliances.

It grows with your child

▲ 0–1 yr

Hide your own face. Babies love the surprise.

■ 1–2 yrs

Hide a toy under the blanket; your child pulls it off.

★ 2–3 yrs

Your child hides under it; you look everywhere else first.

● 3–5 yrs

Hide-and-seek in one room. You count to 10 out loud.

PLAY

2

Pots-and-Spoons Band



With a grown-up



No prep



About 5 min



Nothing to buy



You need: A pot or plastic bowl, a wooden spoon

How to play

- 1 Turn a pot upside down.
- 2 Tap it loud, then soft.
- 3 Take turns: you play, then your child copies, then swap.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · SING AND GESTURE

“Loud! ... (whisper) quiet.”

Why it works

Loud and quiet, stop and go: copying each other is a conversation without words.

- 2 **Tired? 1-minute version:** Three loud taps, three soft taps, done.



Safety: Cool, empty pots, away from the stove. A wooden or plastic spoon.

It grows with your child

▲ 0–1 yr

Tap gently while your baby watches and reaches.

■ 1–2 yrs

Hand over the spoon. Clap after every bang.

★ 2–3 yrs

Stop and start: bang when you nod, freeze when you stop.

● 3–5 yrs

Copy my pattern: tap, tap, BANG. Then your child makes one.

PLAY

3

Cup Tower Crash



With a grown-up



No prep



About 5 min



Nothing to buy



You need: 3–6 plastic cups or containers

How to play

- 1 Stack the cups into a tower.
- 2 Count down together: “3, 2, 1...”
- 3 Crash! Then build it again.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT

“Up, up, up... (wait) CRASH!”



Why it works

The wait before the crash is the best part. That pause gives your child a turn to join in.

- 2 **Tired? 1-minute version:** One tower, one crash.



Safety: Plastic cups too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube. Keep towers below your child’s chest.

It grows with your child

▲ 0–1 yr

You stack two; your baby knocks them over.

■ 1–2 yrs

Stack two together, then crash.

★ 2–3 yrs

Build as tall as you can before it falls.

● 3–5 yrs

Big cup at the bottom, smallest on top: put them in order.

PLAY

4

Window Walk



With a grown-up



No prep



About 5 min



Nothing to buy



You need: A window

How to play

- 1 Stand or sit at a window together.
- 2 Say what you see: a tree, a car, a bird.
- 3 Wait. Then say what your child is looking at.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

“A car! (wait) A big red car.”



Why it works

Naming what your child is already looking at puts words right where their attention is.

- 2 **Tired? 1-minute version:** Name three things you can see, then wave goodbye.



Safety: Closed, locked windows. A grown-up lifts; nobody stands on sills or furniture.

It grows with your child

▲ 0–1 yr

Hold your baby up and name one thing slowly.

■ 1–2 yrs

Point, wait, then name what your child points at.

★ 2–3 yrs

Play “I see something...”: you name a color.

● 3–5 yrs

Count something: cars, birds, windows across the street.

PLAY

5

Sock Friend Says Hello



With a grown-up



No prep



About 5 min



Nothing to buy



You need: A clean sock

How to play

- 1 Put a sock on your hand. It's a sock friend!
- 2 The sock friend says hello and asks a question.
- 3 Wait for any answer: a look, a sound, a word.



TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT

"Hello! (wait) What's your name?"



Why it works

A silly voice makes it easy to take turns talking, and any answer counts.

- 2 **Tired? 1-minute version:** One sock, one "Hello!", one tickle.



Safety: A clean sock with nothing sewn or glued on: no buttons, beads or pom-poms.

It grows with your child

▲ 0–1 yr

The sock friend sings and gently tickles toes.

■ 1–2 yrs

The sock friend hides under your arm, then pops out.

★ 2–3 yrs

The sock friend is hungry: your child "feeds" it pretend food.

● 3–5 yrs

Your child wears the sock and talks to you.

Our safety rules



A grown-up plays too

Every play is for a child and a grown-up together. Stay close and watch.



The toilet-paper tube test

For children under 3, anything that fits through a toilet-paper tube (about 1.25 in or 3.2 cm) stays out of reach.



Awake-time play

Blankets and soft things are for awake play with you, never in a baby's sleep space.



No cords, no balloons

No cords, strings or ties long enough to go around a neck. No balloons for children under 8.

These are everyday play ideas for families, not medical or developmental advice. Questions about your child's growth or health? Your child's doctor is a good place to start.

What comes next in your inbox



Once a month: 3 plays for your child's age

If you gave us your child's birth month and year, each email matches their age. If not, you get plays for every age. Nothing else is needed.



Our privacy promise

We never ask for a child's name, photo or full birth date, only an optional birth month and year. We never sell your email or share it with anyone except the service that sends our emails. Every email has a one-click unsubscribe.

More from Play Before Pixels



52 Play & Talk Cards

One play and one talk tip on every card, for ages 0–5: a card a week for a year.



100 Screen-Free Plays

A quick play for every age and every moment of an ordinary day.

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